



## Heidegger -2

Science Technology & Society (PATTS College of Aeronautics)



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## **Questioning as the Piety of Thought**

Heidegger concluded his treatise on technology as follows:

*The closer we come to the danger, the more brightly do the ways into the saving power begin to shine and the more questioning we become. For questioning is the piety of thought (1977, p. 19).*

Heidegger underscored the importance of questioning in the midst of technology. For him, there is unparalleled wisdom gained only when man is able to pause, think, and question. Humans are swallowed by technology when they are caught up in the enframing of technology and fail to pay attention to the intricacies of technology, the brilliance of their purpose, and the genius of individuals that put them forth.

Questioning is the piety of thought. It is only through questioning that we are able to reassess our position not only in the midst of technology around us, but also and importantly in the grand scheme of things. Heidegger posited that it is through questioning that we bear witness to the crises that a complete preoccupation with technology brings, preventing us from experiencing the essence of technology, and that a complete aesthetic-mindedness prohibits us from guarding and preserving the essence of art. Thus, we need to take a step back and reassess who we were, who we are, and who are we becoming in the midst of technology.

## **UNIT 2. HUMAN FLOURISHING IN PROGRESS AND DEVELOPMENT**

This unit presents Jason Hickel's development framework described as 'de-developing' rich countries. As a departure from traditional frameworks of growth and development, Hickel's 'de-developing' framework is discussed as an alternative to narrowing the gap between rich and poor countries. Thus, taking off from this alternative framework, the unit critiques human

flourishing vis-à-vis progress in science and technology, so that students can define for themselves the meaning of the good life.

## **Thoughts to Ponder**

Despite efforts to close out the gap between poor and rich countries, a 2015 BBC report stated that the growth gap keeps widening. Although there is no standard measure of inequality, the report claimed that most indicators suggest that the widening of the growth gap slowed or fell during the financial crisis and is now growing again. Continued sharpening of inequality appears paradoxical having in mind the efforts that had been poured in on development efforts to assist poor countries to rise from absent to slow progress.

At this backdrop, we could not help but ask ourselves whether we are indeed progressing. In the context of unprecedented scientific and technological advancement and economic development, we ask ourselves whether we, humans, either as individuals or as a collective, are indeed flourishing. If development efforts to close out the gap between the rich and poor countries have failed, can we possibly confront the challenges of development through a nonconformist framework?

In the succeeding article, Jason Hickel, an anthropologist at the London School of Economics, criticize the failure of growth and development efforts dating back to seven decades ago to eradicate poverty and offers a nonconformist perspective toward growth and development.

### **Forget 'developing' poor countries, it's time to 'de-develop' rich countries**

by Jason Hickel

This week, heads of state are gathering in New York to sign the UN's new sustainable development goals (SDGs). The main objective is to eradicate poverty by 2030. Beyoncé, One Direction and Malala are on board. It's set to be a monumental international celebration.

Given all the fanfare, one might think the SDGs are about to offer a fresh plan for how to save the world, but beneath all the hype, it's business as usual. The main strategy for eradicating poverty is the same: growth.

Growth has been the main object of development for the past 70 years, despite the fact that it's not working. Since 1980, the global economy has grown by 380%, but the number of people living in poverty on less than \$5 (£3.20) a day has increased by more than 1.1 billion. That's 17 times the population of Britain. So much for the trickle-down effect.

Orthodox economists insist that all we need is yet more growth. More progressive types tell us that we need to shift some of the yields of growth from the richer segments of the population to the poorer ones, evening things out a bit. Neither approach is adequate. Why? Because even at current levels of average global consumption, we're overshooting our planet's bio-capacity by more than 50% each year. PAGE 64

In other words, growth isn't an option any more – we've already grown too much. Scientists are now telling us that we're blowing past planetary boundaries at breakneck speed. And the hard truth is that this global crisis is due almost entirely to overconsumption in rich countries.

Right now, our planet only has enough resources for each of us to consume 1.8 “global hectares” annually – a standardised unit that measures resource use and waste. This figure is roughly what the average person in Ghana or Guatemala consumes. By contrast, people in the US and Canada consume about 8 hectares per person, while Europeans consume 4.7 hectares – many times their fair share.

What does this mean for our theory of development? Economist Peter Edward argues that instead of pushing poorer countries to “catch up” with rich ones, we should be thinking of ways to get rich countries to “catch down” to more appropriate levels of development. We should look at societies where people live long and happy lives at relatively low levels of income and consumption not as basket cases that need to be developed towards western models, but as exemplars of efficient living.

How much do we really need to live long and happy lives? In the US, life expectancy is 79 years and GDP per capita is \$53,000. But many countries have achieved similar life expectancy with a mere fraction of this income. Cuba has a comparable life expectancy to the US and one of the highest literacy rates in the world with GDP per capita of only \$6,000 and consumption of only 1.9 hectares – right at the threshold of ecological sustainability. Similar claims can be made of Peru, Ecuador, Honduras, Nicaragua and Tunisia.

Yes, some of the excess income and consumption we see in the rich world yields improvements in quality of life that are not captured by life expectancy, or even literacy rates. But even if we look at measures of overall happiness and wellbeing in addition to life expectancy, a number of low- and middle-income countries rank highly. Costa Rica manages to

sustain one of the highest happiness indicators and life expectancies in the world with a per capita income one-fourth that of the US.

In light of this, perhaps we should regard such countries not as underdeveloped, but rather as appropriately developed. And maybe we need to start calling on rich countries to justify their excesses.

The idea of “de-developing” rich countries might prove to be a strong rallying cry in the global south, but it will be tricky to sell to westerners. Tricky, but not impossible. According to recent consumer research, 70% of people in middle- and high-income countries believe overconsumption is putting our planet and society at risk. A similar majority also believe we should strive to buy and own less, and that doing so would not compromise our happiness. People sense there is something wrong with the dominant model of economic progress and they are hungry for an alternative narrative. PAGE 65

The problem is that the pundits promoting this kind of transition are using the wrong language. They use terms such as de-growth, zero growth or – worst of all – de-development, which are technically accurate but off-putting for anyone who's not already on board. Such terms are repulsive because they run against the deepest frames we use to think about human progress, and, indeed, the purpose of life itself. It's like asking people to stop moving positively thorough life, to stop learning, improving, growing.

Negative formulations won't get us anywhere. The idea of "steady-state" economics is a step in the right direction and is growing in popularity, but it still doesn't get the framing right. We need to reorient ourselves toward a positive future, a truer form of progress. One that is geared toward quality instead of quantity. One that is more sophisticated than just accumulating ever increasing amounts of stuff, which doesn't make anyone happier anyway. What is certain is that GDP as a measure is not going to get us there and we need to get rid of it.

Perhaps we might take a cue from Latin Americans, who are organising alternative visions around the indigenous concept of *buen vivir*, or good living. The west has its own tradition of reflection on the good life and it's time we revive it. Robert and Edward Skidelsky take us down this road in his book, *How Much is Enough?*, where they lay out the possibility of interventions such as banning advertising, a shorter working week and a basic income, all of which would improve our lives while reducing consumption.

Either we slow down voluntarily or climate change will do it for us. We can't go on ignoring the laws of nature. But rethinking our theory of progress is not only an ecological imperative, it is also a development one. If we do not act soon, all our hard-won gains against poverty will evaporate, as food systems collapse and mass famine re-emerges to an extent not seen since the 19th century.

This is not about giving anything up. And it's certainly not about living a life of voluntary misery or imposing harsh limits on human potential. On the

contrary, it's about reaching a higher level of understanding and consciousness about what we're doing here and why.

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Follow @jasonhickel on Twitter.

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### UNIT 3. THE GOOD LIFE

This unit introduces concepts from Aristotle's *Nichomachean Ethics* and examines contemporary science and technology issues using the same philosophical lens. It tackles important Aristotelian concepts of *Eudaimonia*, *arête*, and The Golden Mean and how these could serve to assess one's relationship and dealings with Science and Technology and ultimately answer the question, 'Are we living the good life?'

#### **Intended Learning Outcomes**

*At the end of this unit, students are expected to demonstrate the following outcomes:*

1. Define one's concept of a good life
2. Discuss Aristotle's concept of *Eudaimonia* and the good life.
3. Examine shared concerns that make up the good life in order to come up with innovative and creative solutions to contemporary issues guided by ethical standards.

#### **Learning Checkpoint (4)**

**Instruction:** On the space provided, write whether you AGREE or DISAGREE with each statement.

- \_\_\_\_\_ 1. The purpose of life is happiness.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 2. Happiness comes from pleasure, wealth, and recognition.

- \_\_\_\_\_ 3. Happiness means merely feeling good or joyful.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 4. Reason is an important element of human happiness.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 5. To achieve happiness, humans must pursue only extremely positive things.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 6. A life of happiness is a result of a balance between two extremes.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 7. A happy life is a virtuous life.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 8. Intellectual and moral virtues are the ingredients of happiness.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 9. It is not the role of Science and Technology to guide humans toward a virtuous life.
- \_\_\_\_\_ 10. Ethical standards must be imposed upon Science and Technology to avoid excesses and deficiencies.

### **Are we living the good life?**

This question is inarguably one universal human concern. Everyone aims to lead a good life. Yet, what constitutes a happy and contented life varies from person to person. Unique backgrounds, experiences, social contexts, and even preferences make it difficult to subscribe to a unified standard on which to tease out the meaning of the good life. Thus, the prospect of a standard of the good life, one that resonates across unique human experiences, is inviting. PAGE 71

## **Aristotle's Nichomachean Ethics and the Good Life**

In the beginning of this unit, the question, 'Are we living the good life?' was posed. To answer this question, necessary reflection must be made on two things: first, what standard could be used to define 'the good life'; and second, how can the standard serve as guide toward living the good life in the midst of scientific advancement and technological progress.

In the documentary film, 'The Magician's Twin: C. S. Lewis and the Case Against Scientism,' C. S. Lewis posited that 'science must be guided by some ethical basis that is not dictated by science itself.' One such ethical basis is Aristotle's Nichomachean Ethics.

Aristotle, probably the most important ancient Greek philosopher and scientist, lived from 384 to 322 BC. He was a student of Plato, whereas Plato was a student of Socrates. Together, they are considered the 'Big Three of Greek Philosophy.'

Aristotle's Nichomachean Ethics, the fundamental basis of Aristotelian ethics, consists of ten books. Originally, they were lecture notes written on scrolls, while he taught at the Lyceum. It is widely believed that the lecture notes were compiled by or had been dedicated to one of Aristotle's sons, *Nichomachus*. Alternatively, it is also believed that the work was dedicated to Aristotle's father who was of the same name.

The Nichomachean Ethics, abbreviated as the NE or sometimes EN from the Latin version of the name, is a treatise on the nature of moral life and human happiness, based on the unique essence of human nature. The NE is particularly useful in defining what the good life is.

Everyone has a definition of what is good: getting a college degree, travelling across the world, succeeding in a business venture, pursuing a healthy and active lifestyle, or being a responsible parent. However, although everyone does aim to achieve that which is *good*, Aristotle differentiated between two types of good. In the NE Book 2 Chapter 2, i.e., NE 2:2, Aristotle explained that every action aims at some good. However, some actions aim at an *instrumental good*, while some aim at an *ultimate*

*good*. He made it clear that ultimate goods are better than instrumental goods. The latter, the instrumental goods, are aimed only as far as an individual aims for something else, while the latter, the ultimate goods, are aimed for their own sakes, as ends in themselves.

### ***Eudaimonia: The Ultimate Good***

What then is the ultimate good? Based on the contrast between two types of good, one could reflect on some potential candidates for the ultimate good. One might think that pleasure is the ultimate good. One aims for pleasure in the food they eat or in the experiences they immerse themselves into. Yet, while pleasure is an important human need, it could not be the ultimate good. First, it is transitory – it passes – one might have been pleased with the food they had for lunch, they would be hungry or would want something else after a while. Second, pleasure is not complete. It makes one feel satisfied, but only in one

aspect of living. One maybe pleased with an opportunity to travel, but that does not make them feel good about, say, the studies they left back home or the relationship they have been wanting to remove themselves from.

Others might think that wealth is a potential candidate for the ultimate good, but a critique of wealth would prove otherwise. Indeed, many, if not most, aim to be financially stable, to be rich, or to be able to afford a luxurious life. However, it is very common to hear people say that they aim to be wealthy insofar as it would help them achieve some other goals.

Elsewhere, it is also common to hear stories about people who have achieved immense wealth but remain, by and large, unhappy with the lives they lead. In this sense, wealth is just an intermediate good, clearly only instrumental. It is not the ultimate good, because it is not self-sufficient and does not stop one from aiming for some other 'greater' goods.

Another candidate for the ultimate good is fame and honor. Many people today seem to be motivated by a desire to be known – to be famous. Others, for their part, strive for honor and recognition. This is evidenced by a fairly increasing number of social media personalities who wish to gain a foothold on the benefits that fame brings. Conversely, others' decisions and actions are hugely aimed at the experience of being admired, appreciated, or well-liked by others. However, these could not constitute the ultimate good, simply because they are based on others. For this, fame and honor could never be self-sufficient. If one's definition of the good life is being popular or honorable, then, the good life would be elusive, since it would be based on the fleeting and biased views of others.

Finally, happiness could be the ultimate good. In the Aristotelian sense, happiness is 'living well and doing well' (NE 1:4). Among the Greeks, this was known as *Eudaimonia*, from the root words *eu*, meaning good, and *daimōn*, meaning spirit. Combined, *Eudaimonia* means happiness or welfare. More accurately, others translate it to human flourishing or prosperity. Two hallmarks of *Eudaimonia* had been proposed: *virtue* and *excellence* (NE 1:7). Thus, happiness in the sense of *Eudaimonia* has to be

distinguished from merely feeling good. *Eudaimonia* is more complete as it is feeling well and doing well in all aspects of life.

### ***Eudaimonia: Uniquely Human?***

*Eudaimonia* or happiness must be unique human or a uniquely human function. It is achieved only through a rationally directed life. Consider Table 1 below:

| Table 1. Aristotle's Tripartite Soul |         | Degrees of Soul                                   |                 |
|--------------------------------------|---------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Living Things                        |         | Functions of the Soul                             |                 |
| Rational                             | Humans  | Theoretical<br>Practical<br>(Intellect = Thought) | Rational        |
| Sensitive                            | Animals | Locomotion<br>Perception                          | Partly-rational |
| Nutritive                            | Plants  | Growth<br>Nutrition<br>Reproduction               | Non-rational    |

Aristotle's notion of a tripartite soul as summarized in Table 1 is best understood as a nested hierarchy. The degrees and functions of the soul are nested, simply because one that has a higher degree of soul also has those of the lower degrees. Thus, on the nutritive degree, all living things, i.e., plants, animals, and humans, require nourishment and have an ability to reproduce. On the sensitive degree, only animals and humans have an ability to move and perceive, whereas plants do not have. Finally, on the rational degree, only humans are capable of theoretical and practical functions. Following this, while humans possess the nutritive and sensitive degrees of the soul, they are the only living things with a rational degree of the soul. Thus, only humans are capable of a life guided by reason. Because this is so, happiness, too, is uniquely human, for it can only be achieved through a rationally directed life.

### ***Arête and Human Happiness***

*Eudaimonia* is what defines the good life. To live a good life is to live a happy life. From the immediately preceding discussion, it was made clear

that the Aristotelian notion of happiness is uniquely human, because it could only be possible through a rationally directed life and not from some goods that are either incomplete or insufficient or both. For Aristotle, *Eudaimonia* is possible only by living a life of virtue.

A virtue, or *arête* in Greek, is what makes one function well. Aristotle also explained two types of virtue: intellectual virtue and moral virtue.

Intellectual virtue or virtue of thought is achieved through education, time, and experience. The key intellectual virtues are wisdom, which guide ethical behavior, and understanding, which is gained from scientific endeavor and contemplation. Wisdom and understanding are achieved through formal and non-formal means. Intellectual virtue is in self-taught knowledge and skills as much as those taught and learned in school.

Moral virtue or virtue of character is achieved through habitual practice.

Some of the key moral virtues are generosity, temperance, and courage.

Aristotle explained that, although the capacity for intellectual virtue is innate, it is brought into full only by practice. It is by repeatedly choosing to be kind that one develops the virtue of generosity. It is by repeatedly choosing to resist and forego every inviting opportunity that one develops the virtue of temperance. It is by choosing to repeatedly exhibit the proper action and emotional response in face of danger that one develops the virtue of courage. By and large, moral virtue is like a skill. A skill is learned only through repeated practice. Everyone is capable of learning how to play the guitar, because everyone has an innate capability for intellectual virtue; but not everyone learns it, because only those who devote time and practice develop the skill of playing the instrument. PAGE 74

If one learns that too much fatty food is bad for the health, they have to choose to stay away from this type of food as a habit, because health contributes to feeling well and doing well. If one believes that too much use of social media is detrimental to human relationships and productivity, they must repeatedly choose to spend more time talking to friends and family face-to-face or regulating the use to a level that does not prevent them from being productive, all because healthy relationships allow one to feel well and do well. If one understands the enormous damage brought upon the environment by plastic materials, they must repeatedly forego the next plastic item they could do away with. Like what was previously posited, a healthy environment contributes to humans' feeling well and doing well. Both intellectual virtue and moral virtue should be in accordance with reason in order for *Eudaimonia* to be achieved. Indifference with these virtues, for reasons that are only for one's convenience, pleasure, or satisfaction, leads humans away from *Eudaimonia*.

### ***The Golden Mean***

A virtue is ruined by excess and deficiency in both feelings and action. A balance or intermediate between two extremes is a requisite of virtue. This balance is a mean of excess not in the sense of a geometric or arithmetic average. Instead, it is a mean relative to the person, circumstances, and the right emotional response in every experience (NE 2:2; 2:6).

Consider the virtue of courage. Courage was earlier defined as the display of right action and emotional response in the face of danger. The virtue of courage is ruined by an excess of the needed emotional and/or proper action. The person does not properly assess the danger and is totally without fear. Thus, they develop the vice of fool-heartiness or rashness. Also, courage is ruined by a deficiency of proper emotion and action. When one overthinks of a looming danger, so much so that they become too fearful and incapable of acting on the problem to start with, they develop the vice of cowardice.

### ***What then is the good life?***

Putting everything in perspective, the good life in the sense of Eudaimonia, is a rationally guided life that is complete with emotion, intellect, action, and sociality. The means to the good life are the virtues of thought and character, which are a relative intermediate between two extremes of excess and deficiency. In this way, the good life is understood as happiness brought by living a virtuous life.

One could draw parallels between moving toward the good life and toward further progress and development in Science and Technology. In appraising the goodness of the next medical procedure, the new social media trend, the latest mobile device, or the upcoming technology for food safety, one must be guided by the Aristotelian virtues. Science and Technology could be ruined by under- or over-appreciation of the scope and function that it plays in the pursuit of the uniquely human experience of happiness. Altogether refusing Science and Technology to improve human life is as problematic as allowing it to entirely dictate reason and action without any regard for ethical and moral standard. By imposing on Science and Technology an ethical standard that is not dictated by itself, as C. S. Lewis proposed, not only will scientific advancement and technological development, but also will the human person flourish.

standard that is not dictated by itself, as C. S. Lewis proposed, not only will scientific advancement and technological development, but also will the human person flourish. PAGE 76

### Exercise 1. Reading Comprehension Task

Unit 3. The Good Life

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Course/Section: \_\_\_\_\_

Date Submitted: \_\_\_\_\_

**Instruction:** Compare and contrast each pair of terms related to Aristotle's Nichomachean Ethics as discussed in this unit.

1. Instrumental Good - Ultimate Good

\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_.

2. Pleasure - Happiness

\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_  
\_\_\_\_\_